

THE TRAILBLAZERS

Some leading ladies of India's space sector



T.K. ANURADHA

POST: Programme Director, Communication Satellites, Isro (2016-2018)

CONTRIBUTION: Instrumental in planning and implementation of many satellite projects, focussing on enhancing communication infra. Significantly contributed to advancing satellite tech

S.N. VALARMATHI

POST: Project Director, RISAT-1 (2010-2012)

CONTRIBUTION: Led the RISAT-1 project, launched in 2012. The satellite is designed to deliver all-weather surveillance, crucial for applications in agriculture, forestry, soil moisture estimation, and disaster management

VANITHA M.

POST: Project Director, Chandrayaan-2 (2018-2019)

CONTRIBUTION: Led the Chandrayaan-2 mission, which included an orbiter, lander, and rover, showcasing India's advancements in lunar exploration

NIGAR SHAJI

POST: Project Director, Aditya-L1 (2020-present)

CONTRIBUTION: She currently leads the Aditya-L1 mission, which is India's first solar observatory mission aimed at studying the Sun's outer layers and understanding solar activities and their effects on space weather

ing more women with backgrounds in STEM. In turn, government initiatives such as the 'Women in Science' programme are attracting more women into STEM. Isro says women account for nearly 30% of the Indian space sector's workforce.

T.K. Anuradha, 64, a retired Distinguished Scientist at Isro, attributes the success of India's space missions to teamwork and review mechanisms. Anuradha, who joined Isro in 1982, says the space agency's women perform just as well as men. Isro does not have to juggle with gender equality. However, for women at Isro, as in other jobs, balancing family and demanding work schedules can be daunting. K.L. Shivani, 55, Deputy Director at Isro Telemetry, Tracking, and Command Network, says she has cracked the problem. "I mastered time management and learnt to navigate challenges," she says.

N. Ranjana, 54, Director of Futuristic Technology Management at the Defence Research & Development Organisation (DRDO), says India has followed its formula in getting women into the space programme. "Unlike the US and Europe, where there are structured pathways for women in STEM, India relies heavily on individual merit," she says.

Ranjana says women score over men in terms of focus and perseverance. "Women with a passion for STEM are an asset, as their natural qualities enhance their contributions," she says.

Ranjana says balancing work-life challenges is not restricted to women: It is about how individuals manage their time and prioritise. Everyone, regardless of gender, must make choices between work and personal life, especially in demanding fields like space technology. "In my experience, it's not a gender issue but more of self-belief and finding the necessary support to nurture your pas-

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N. RANJANA

Director, Futuristic Technology Management, DRDO